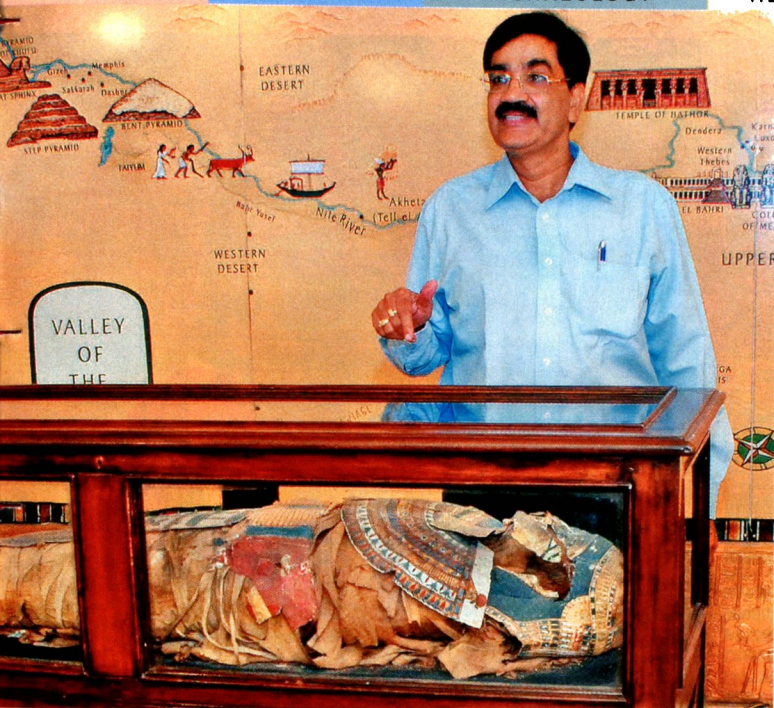




REDDY WITH THE MUMMY AT
THE STATE ARCHAEOLOGICAL
MUSEUM, HYDERABAD

amends like replacing the tightly rolled linen as well as the stuffing put in place of the organs that were removed following mummification rituals with scientifically-treated material. Much more has to be done in Nasihu's case as the face and legs also have to be restored. "We know little and have to rely on Egypt's experts who luckily have come to our rescue," admits Reddy.

But curators with the custody of mummies in other Indian museums have little to preen about. Pollution, light, humidity, temperature, algae, fungi, bacteria, and insects have a deteriorating effect on museum material, particularly mummies. More than a decade ago, experts conferred and concluded that the 1.54-m-long Egyptian princess in the Egypto-Babylonian Gallery at the Baroda Museum and Picture Gallery, Vadodara, needs an oxygen free glass chamber if it is to be conserved. But the decision has been put on hold till now. This one had been purchased by Sayajirao Gaekwad III from New York in 1895 for \$175.

Evidently, the former princely rulers

appreciated the need of having collections in museums for a rich educational experience. This is how the 2,300-year-old mummy of an Egyptian priestess of the Ptolemaic dynasty that ruled Egypt for nearly 300 years between 305 B.C. and 30 B.C. has emerged as a big attraction at the Albert Hall Museum, Jaipur. Egyptian alabaster figures and scriptures create the right ambience in the room where the mummy is on display but even this is decaying fast—a story repeated at other museums in the country. In sharp contrast, newer imaging tools and the use of multi-media methods is making interests in the mummies a bigger draw and an enchanting experience in museums abroad.

Some five years ago, the British Museum offered visitors the opportunity to step into an immersive 3D environment to see what lies beneath the wrappings of Nesperennub, an important priest in ancient Egypt, who has been

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Archaeology and Museums*

housed in the museum since 1899. The immersive experience allows visitors wearing 3D-stereo eyeglasses to virtually explore the tomb in which Nesperennub was buried next to his wife. Viewers are then taken inside the wrappings of the mummy and can also see Nesperennub's facial features, completely reconstructed to give an accurate visual image of the priest. The image then morphs into a human actor and a reconstruction of how Nesperennub would have lived is dramatised. Visitors to the museum are then able to witness the ancient Egyptian rituals of preserving the dead 3,000 years ago, including details of where incisions were made to remove organs. All this virtual unwrapping is done even as the mummy remains undisturbed and intact.

Mummies serve as important time capsules of a distant past. From destructive beginnings in the Middle Ages, when mummies were ground to powder as medicinal cures for wealthy Europeans, to the destructive unwrapping techniques employed by scientists in the 19th and 20th centuries, to today's non-invasive CAT scans, it is an extraordinary learning. Evaluation with high resolution CT and reformation techniques show that the mummy is much more interesting than a skeleton, as the soft tissue contains a great deal of information that the bone does not. The modern analysis of mummies and their ancient DNA not only increases our understanding of ancient Egypt, but provides potentially valuable clues to our future as well. Sadly, little is being done in India to preserve and present what represents valuable evidence of our ancient past. Nasihu's fate could have been buried and forgotten had it not been for a diplomatic twist of fate. ■